

The IELTS Academic Revision Playbook

A complete strategy book for reaching band 7.0. Ten chapters. Every factual claim about format, timing and scoring was verified against official sources on 31 July 2026 — see [knowledge/sources.md](#).

All content here is original. No official test material or official band descriptor wording is reproduced.

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Chapter 1 — How the test and the scoring actually work

The shape of the day

IELTS Academic runs **2 hours 45 minutes** for Listening, Reading and Writing, taken back-to-back with no break. Speaking is 11–14 minutes and may be on a different day.

Paper	Content	Time
Listening	4 parts × 10 questions = 40	~30 min
Reading	3 passages, 40 questions, 2,150–2,750 words	60 min, no transfer time
Writing	Task 1 (≥150 words) + Task 2 (≥250 words)	60 min
Speaking	3 parts	11–14 min

The change you need to know about

IELTS stopped offering paper-based testing from mid-2026. All tests are now computer-delivered, with exact timelines varying by market. A "Writing on Paper" option — computer test, handwritten Writing — exists in selected markets.

The skills assessed and the way results are interpreted have **not** changed. Research supports score comparability across delivery modes. But two practical things changed, and both affect how you train:

1. **Listening has no transfer time.** On paper you got 10 extra minutes to copy answers onto a sheet. On computer you type as you listen and get **2 minutes** to check at the end. There is no tidying-up phase any more.
2. **Writing is typed.** Your typing speed, and your ability to proofread on a screen, are now part of your Writing score. Practise by typing.

How the bands are calculated

Listening and Reading are objective: 40 questions, one mark each, **no negative marking**. Never leave a blank.

Band	Listening	Academic Reading
5	16	15
6	23	23
7	30	30
8	35	35

Conversion varies slightly between test versions. Treat these as targets.

Writing and Speaking are examiner-judged against four criteria each, weighted equally within the paper. **Within Writing, Task 2 counts twice as much as Task 1.**

$$\text{Writing band} = (\text{Task 1} + 2 \times \text{Task 2}) \div 3$$

Overall band = the mean of the four skill bands, rounded to the nearest half band. An average ending in .25 rounds up to the next half band; .75 rounds up to the next whole band.

$$6.5 / 6.5 / 5.0 / 7.0 \rightarrow \text{average } 6.25 \rightarrow \text{reported } 6.5$$

The strategic insight

You do not need band 7 in every skill to get 7.0 overall.

L	R	W	S	Average	Reported
7.5	7.5	6.0	6.5	6.875	7.0
7.0	7.0	6.5	6.5	6.75	7.0
8.0	7.0	6.0	6.5	6.875	7.0
6.5	6.5	6.5	6.5	6.5	6.5 ✗

Look at the last row. Uniform competence at 6.5 gets you 6.5. Two strong skills carrying two adequate ones gets you 7.0.

This should shape everything you do. **Listening and Reading are the cheapest bands to buy.** They are objective, technique-driven, and 30/40 is a training problem rather than a talent problem — you can add three or four correct answers through method alone. Writing is the slowest to move because it depends on grammatical accuracy built over months. So: start Writing earliest, work it longest, but expect your fastest gains in Reading and Listening.

Chapter 2 — Listening: every trap and how to beat it

Four parts, progressively harder. Parts 1–2 are everyday and social; Parts 3–4 are educational. Part 4 is a single academic lecture with no break in the middle.

The one rule that governs everything

Answers come in order. Always, within a question set.

The most expensive mistake in the Listening paper is not mishearing an answer — it is *chasing* one. If you are hunting for Q17 and hear something that clearly answers Q19, then 17 and 18 are gone. Type a plausible guess for them immediately and lock on to 19. Candidates who chase a missed answer backwards routinely lose the next three as well. One lost mark becomes four.

Predict before you listen

Use every second of reading time. For each gap, decide three things:

1. **What type of word?** Number, date, time, name, place, noun, verb, adjective.
2. **Singular or plural?**
3. **What two or three words would I expect?**

"The library closes at _____" can only take a time. You have converted an open listening problem into a closed one. This single habit is worth more marks than any other Listening technique.

The five traps

1. The correction trap. Speakers change their minds mid-sentence, and the first value you hear is often wrong. Listen for the reversal signal — *sorry, actually, I mean, no wait, let me check, or rather, in fact*.

▮ *"The deposit is fifty pounds — sorry, that's the monthly rent. The deposit's **a hundred and twenty**."*

The answer is what comes after the correction. Test writers know that candidates write the first number they hear and stop listening.

2. Rejected-option distractors. In multiple choice, all three options are usually mentioned. Two get rejected. Listen for rejection language: *we did consider X, but... / originally we planned X, however... / I'd have preferred X*. Hearing a word is not the same as it being the answer.

3. The plural trap. "Two tickets" written as *ticket* is wrong. Decide singular or plural during prediction, then confirm from the audio.

4. Word-limit bait. The natural way to say something is often four words when the limit is two. "NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS" means three words scores **zero**, even when the meaning is perfect. Hyphenated words count as one.

5. The paraphrase. The question's words never appear in the audio; the idea does. You are listening for meaning, not for a string match.

Spelling is a free band

A misspelled answer is wrong, however clearly you heard it. Names and unusual words get spelled out in the audio — write the letters as they come.

The recurring offenders: *accommodation · questionnaire · restaurant · February · Wednesday · necessary · separate · definitely · receipt · brochure · itinerary · vehicle · colleague · maintenance · equipment · environment · government · beginning · committee · recommend · library · foreign · schedule · laboratory · temperature.*

And the number pairs that cost marks every session: **thirteen/thirty, fourteen/forty, fifteen/fifty**. The stress moves — thir-**TEEN** versus **THIR**-ty. Drill this specifically; it is a listening skill, not a vocabulary one.

Training without audio

Text-based drills (/listening) build prediction, trap recognition, spelling and answer-order discipline. They cannot build ear-training. Do **one official free Listening test per week** under real conditions — no pausing, no replaying, typed answers, 2-minute check — and bring the raw score and missed question numbers back for analysis.

Chapter 3 — Reading: a playbook per question type

3 passages, 40 questions, 60 minutes, **no transfer time**.

Prep sites almost universally claim the passages get progressively harder. No official source says so — so do not build your plan on it. Build it on the clock.

The time budget is the skill

Cambridge's own guidance is **about 20 minutes on each passage**. That is the official baseline and it is perfectly good. The front-loaded split beside it is a personal tactic that compresses Passage 1 to buy time for Passage 3 — worth using only if Passage 1 genuinely comes easier to you.

Passage	Even split (official)	Front-loaded (tactic)
1	20 min	16 min
2	20 min	19 min
3	20 min	21 min
Check and guess	—	4 min

Set hard stops and obey them. Spending an extra ten minutes on Passage 1 to secure two marks costs you five in Passage 3, where you then run out of time entirely. This is the single commonest way capable readers score 6 instead of 7.

If a question resists for 90 seconds, guess and move on. You can come back.

Scan, don't read

You do not have time to read 2,700 words properly. You have time to read them *purposefully*.

1. **60 seconds skimming** — title, first and last sentence of each paragraph. Build a rough map of what lives where.
2. **Read the questions**, which tell you what to hunt for.
3. **Anchor on unparaphraseable keywords** — proper nouns, dates, numbers, technical terms, capitalised words. These survive paraphrasing and are your fastest route into the text.
4. **Read intensively only around the anchor** — the sentence before, the sentence itself, the sentence after.

The paraphrase principle

The answer is almost never in the question's words. **The paraphrase is the test.** The question says *reduce costs*; the passage says *curtail expenditure*. The question says *abandoned by 800 CE*; the passage says *nothing postdating the eighth century*.

Train yourself to hold the *idea* in mind while scanning, not the words.

True / False / Not Given — where most marks are lost

- **True** — the passage states it, in different words.
- **False** — the passage states the **opposite**. There must be a contradiction you can point to.
- **Not Given** — the passage does not address it.

The whole difficulty is False versus Not Given. Apply one test: *can I point to the specific sentence that contradicts this statement?* If yes, False. If you find yourself reasoning "well, it probably isn't, because..." — that is inference, and the answer is **Not Given**.

Never use outside knowledge. Everything you know about the topic is irrelevant and actively dangerous.

Qualifier traps. Watch *all, always, never, only, exclusively, the most, majority*. If the statement says *all* and the passage says *many*, that is **False** — the qualifier is the claim. If the statement says *some* and the passage says *many*, that is True.

Yes / No / Not Given works identically, but concerns the **writer's opinions and claims** rather than facts. Look for opinion markers: *arguably, it seems likely, critics maintain, the author contends*.

Every other type

Matching Headings — do these **first**; they force you to map the passage. The topic sentence usually carries the heading; read the first and last sentence of each paragraph. Cross off headings as you use them. The classic error is choosing a heading that matches one interesting *detail* rather than the paragraph's **main idea**.

Matching Information to paragraphs — the slowest type. Answers are **not** in order, and one paragraph may hold two or none. Always do these **last**.

Multiple choice — read the stem, predict the answer, *then* read the options. Eliminate: options that are true but do not answer the stem; options that overstate; options containing a passage word used in a different sense.

Sentence completion — answers **are** in passage order. Predict the grammar of the gap before you search, and obey the word limit absolutely.

Summary / note / table / flow-chart completion — answers are **not** guaranteed to follow passage order; only *sentence* completion is ordered. If words come from a box they may be paraphrased; if they come "from the passage", copy them exactly, spelling included.

Matching features (researchers to findings, etc.) — options may be reused **only if the instructions say so**. Assume each is used once unless told otherwise. Scan for the proper nouns first, then read around each.

Short answer — word limit, words from the passage.

Guessing

No negative marking. Never leave a blank.

But ignore the widespread advice that **Not Given** is the safest blind guess on True/False/Not Given. No official data supports it, and treating it as a rule trains you to reach for Not Given before you have finished looking — converting findable answers into misses. Search properly. Guess only when the clock forces it, and then guess what your partial reading actually supports.

Chapter 4 — Writing Task 1: blueprint and language toolkit

≥150 words, ~20 minutes, one third of the Writing band. You describe visual information in your own words.

The four-paragraph blueprint

1. **Introduction — one sentence.** Paraphrase the prompt. Change the nouns and the verb; keep the data. Never copy the prompt: copied text is excluded from your word count.
2. **Overview — two or three sentences. MANDATORY.** The biggest patterns, with **no specific numbers**. What is highest, lowest, rising, falling; what changed most. Signal it: *Overall*,
3. **Body 1 — three or four sentences.** One logical group, with figures.
4. **Body 2 — three or four sentences.** The rest.

Target 170–190 words. **No conclusion. No opinions. No causes.** You cannot know *why* the data moved, and speculating costs you Task Achievement marks.

The overview is the whole ballgame

Without an overview you cannot reach band 7 on Task Achievement, regardless of how good your English is. It is the single most expensive omission in Task 1, and it takes two sentences.

Group; never list

Band-5 writing walks along the x-axis:

| *In 1990 it was 10. In 1991 it was 12. In 1992 it was 15.*

Band-7 writing groups:

| *The three European markets followed broadly the same upward path, whereas both Asian markets contracted sharply after 2005.*

Group by shared trend, similar magnitude, biggest versus smallest, or the outlier.

The language toolkit

Upward: rise · climb · grow · surge · soar · rocket · escalate · pick up **Downward:** fall · decline · drop · plunge · plummet · dip · tail off · slump **Flat:** remain stable / constant / unchanged · level off · plateau **Turning:** peak at · bottom out · fluctuate · recover · rebound

Degree: dramatically · sharply · steeply · markedly · significantly · moderately · gradually · slightly · marginally

Speed: rapidly · swiftly · steadily · slowly

Alternate the two grammatical shapes — using only one is a range limitation:

- verb + adverb — *Sales rose sharply.*
- there + be + adjective + noun — *There was a sharp rise in sales.*

Comparison: twice as many as · three times higher than · roughly half · accounted for X% of · compared with · whereas · by contrast · while · outstripped · lagged behind **Approximation:** approximately · around · just over / under · nearly · almost · in the region of **Proportion:** a quarter · a third · two thirds · the vast majority · a significant minority · one in five · a negligible proportion

Process diagrams need sequencers (*initially, subsequently, following this, at this stage, once X has been completed, finally*) and the **passive voice** (*the mixture is heated, the components are assembled*). Count the stages, name the start and end points, say whether it is linear or cyclical.

Maps over time need past or present perfect passives (*a car park was constructed, the woodland has been cleared*) plus position language (*to the north of, adjacent to, on the outskirts, in the south-east corner, was replaced by, was converted into, remained untouched*).

Before you stop

Overview present and genuinely summarising · ≥150 words counted · figures and units accurate · data grouped not listed · tense correct · no opinion, cause or conclusion · prompt paraphrased not copied.

Chapter 5 — Writing Task 2: blueprint, families, killers

≥250 words, ~40 minutes, **worth double Task 1**. If time runs short, protect Task 2.

The five question families

Misreading the family is the most expensive error in the paper, because it destroys Task Response — the hardest criterion to recover.

One caveat first: **IELTS publishes no official taxonomy of Task 2 question types**. This five-way split is a recognition heuristic, and a useful one, but it is not handed down by the test makers — the British Council's teaching pages give five categories and IDP's give six, and they do not map onto each other. Use the families to make sure you have caught every part of the question, not as a set of boxes every prompt must fit.

1. Opinion. *To what extent do you agree or disagree?* Pick **one** position and hold it. You may concede a point, but a wobbling answer is band 6.

2. Discussion. *Discuss both views and give your own opinion.* Two body paragraphs, one per view, **plus your own opinion given real weight**. The commonest band-6 failure in the entire test is discussing both sides competently and appending the opinion as a final clause.

3. Problem / cause and solution. *What are the causes and what measures could be taken?* Body 1 = causes, Body 2 = solutions — and **the solutions must address the causes you named**. Mismatched halves cost both Task Response and Coherence.

4. Advantages / disadvantages. *Do the advantages outweigh the disadvantages?* If it says *outweigh*, you must **weigh** and give a verdict. Three of each and stop does not answer the question asked.

5. Two-part / direct question. *Why is this happening? Is it a positive or negative development?* **Both parts, separate paragraphs, equal weight**. Half-answering is an automatic band 6.

Spend five minutes planning

Underline the topic, the task word, and **every question part**. Write your position in one sentence. List two main ideas with one example each. Then write. Planning means you are not thinking and phrasing simultaneously, which is where grammatical accuracy collapses.

The blueprint

Introduction (2–3 sentences, ~45 words)

Paraphrase the prompt · state your position

Body 1 (~90 words)

Topic sentence · WHY · example or consequence · link

Body 2 (~90 words)

Topic sentence · WHY · example or consequence · link

Conclusion (2 sentences, ~40 words)

Restate the position in new words · no new ideas

Target 260–290 words — but know what the limit really is. There is a **floor and no ceiling**: an official examiner-marked exemplar scoring 7.5 runs to about **375 words**. Length is not the risk. The risk is writing words you then have no time to check, and accuracy is where band 7 is decided.

Under 250 is not an arithmetic penalty either. IELTS publishes no deduction and the May 2023 descriptors contain none. A short essay simply cannot have fully addressed the prompt, so **Task Response** falls, and it shows less range, so **Lexical Resource** and **Grammar** fall with it. The only published hard threshold is 20 words or fewer → band 1.

Develop, do not assert

This separates 6 from 7 more than anything else. Band 6 states ideas; band 7 *extends* them.

Asserted (band 6): *Online learning is convenient for students.*

Developed (band 7): *Online learning removes the commute, which for students in rural areas can consume two hours a day. That reclaimed time goes into study rather than travel, so the same course delivers more actual learning — particularly for students who also work.*

The pattern: **claim** → **because** → **so what** → **concrete instance**.

The band-7 killers

1. **A question part unanswered.** Fatal for Task Response.
2. **Undeveloped paragraphs** — claims with no reasoning.
3. **Memorised openers.** *In this contemporary era of rapid globalisation...* Examiners see it constantly; it earns nothing and signals a template.
4. **Linker spam.** An examiner logged four sequencers in one paragraph of a band-7.5 essay as "some overuse" — so treat **two per paragraph** as your ceiling. Under-use is penalised too: a 6.5 script was docked for too few.
5. **Informal register** — real, but less fatal than most guides claim. The same official 7.5 script uses *don't* three times and writes "In my opinion, I think". Tidy your register; don't believe a contraction cost you the band.
6. **Under length** — via Task Response and reduced evidence of range, not via a published penalty. See the length note above.
7. **Thesaurus abuse.** *Ameliorate the pecuniary situation* scores **lower** than *improve finances* because the collocation is wrong.
8. **Overgeneralising.** *All young people are addicted to phones.* Hedge it: *many, tend to, are likely to, in most cases.*

A worked skeleton

Some people believe university education should be free for all students. Others think students should pay.
Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

- **Introduction.** Paraphrase. Position: funding should be means-tested — free for those who cannot pay, contributory for those who can.
- **Body 1 (the free-education view).** Claim: removes financial barriers. Because: talent is distributed evenly across income, but opportunity is not. So what: the state loses capable graduates it could have had. Instance: able students entering work at eighteen for family income reasons.
- **Body 2 (the fee-paying view).** Claim: fees fund quality and place cost on those who benefit. Because: graduates earn a measurable premium over their careers. So what: free provision transfers money from non-graduate taxpayers to future high earners.
- **Conclusion.** Both positions have force; means-testing captures the strength of each. Restate in fresh words.

Notice that the opinion is not bolted on at the end — it is announced in the introduction and the two bodies are arranged to support it.

Chapter 6 — Speaking: all three parts

11–14 minutes, face-to-face, recorded. Four criteria weighted equally: Fluency & Coherence, Lexical Resource, Grammatical Range & Accuracy, Pronunciation.

Part 1 — Introduction and interview (4–5 min)

Familiar topics: home, family, work, study, hobbies, food, weather. It feels like a warm-up. It is marked.

Answer + Reason + Example. Two or three sentences. Never one word; never a ninety-second monologue.

Do you enjoy cooking?

Band 5: *Yes, I like it.*

Band 7: *I do, though mainly at weekends — during the week I rarely get home before eight. On Sundays I'll cook properly, usually something Tunisian like a couscous, because it's the one meal the whole family sits down for.*

Part 2 — The long turn (3–4 min including preparation)

A cue card, **one minute of preparation**, then **one to two minutes** speaking uninterrupted.

Use the preparation minute properly. Do not write sentences — you will read them aloud and sound flat, and flat delivery costs you Pronunciation and Fluency. Write **keywords only**, one line per bullet, plus one detail you can expand.

Fill the time. Stopping at forty seconds hurts Fluency directly. If you run dry, extend with: how you felt about it · how it compares to something else · whether you would do it again · what someone else thought · why it stayed with you.

Invent freely. Nobody verifies your story. A vivid invented answer beats a true but thin one every time.

Part 3 — Discussion (4–5 min)

Abstract questions related to the Part 2 topic. **This is where band 7 is won or lost.** It demands opinion, analysis, speculation and comparison — the things Part 1 never asks for.

Speculating: *It's likely that... · I'd imagine... · That could well lead to... · Presumably... · There's a good chance that...*

Conceding, then countering: *That's true up to a point, but... · I can see why people say that, although... · Granted, ... even so, ...*

Comparing: *Whereas in the past... · Compared with a generation ago... · Unlike in Europe, in Tunisia... · By contrast...*

Generalising carefully: *Broadly speaking... · As a rule... · In most cases... · There are exceptions, but generally...*

Buying thinking time: *That's an interesting question... · I've not thought about it that way, but I'd say... — one or two per test, not per answer.*

Expect pushback. *But couldn't you argue the opposite?* is not hostility; it is the examiner testing whether you can defend or refine a position. Do both: concede what is fair, then hold your ground with a reason.

Why memorised answers fail

Examiners are trained to spot them and they are penalised. Memorised speech gives itself away three ways: the register jumps to written-formal, the delivery flattens, and the answer drifts off the question actually asked. Learn flexible frameworks and collocations — never scripts.

Pronunciation is intelligibility, not accent

Your Tunisian and French-influenced accent costs you **nothing**. Band 8 explicitly allows an L1 accent with minimal effect on intelligibility.

What does cost marks:

- **Word stress** in the wrong place — *com-FOR-table*, or the French habit of stressing final syllables.
- **Flat intonation** that hides sentence boundaries and which word carries the point.
- **Sounds that break recognition**: /θ/ and /ð/ (*think, this*), dropped or added /h/, and English **final** consonant clusters (*asked, texts, strengths*).

Two corrections to the standard advice, specific to you. **/p/ vs /b/ is probably not a missing sound** — French supplies /p/; what you likely lack is the **aspiration** English puts on /p/ at the start of a stressed syllable, which is what makes *pear* sound like *bear*. Hold a paper strip at your mouth: it should move on *pin*, not *bin*. And **ignore the usual advice that Arabic speakers break up initial clusters** (*istudy*) — that comes from Modern Standard and Gulf phonotactics. Tunisian Arabic permits two-consonant onsets, so your difficulty is at the **end** of words, not the start. - **Speaking too fast** in pursuit of fluency. Fluency is continuity, not speed.

Record yourself on your phone for every Part 2 you practise and listen back once. Text-based coaching cannot hear you; this is the part you must close yourself.

Chapter 7 — Six structures that buy band 7, and the L1 checklist

The six structures

Band 7 requires "a variety of complex structures with some flexibility and accuracy" and **frequent error-free sentences**. Accuracy beats ambition: a correct complex sentence earns; a broken one costs twice. Master six and use them accurately rather than attempting twelve badly.

1. Relative clauses (especially non-defining).

Students who work part-time report higher stress levels. Tunisia, which has invested heavily in higher education, still sees graduate unemployment.

2. Conditionals — second and third.

If governments subsidised public transport, congestion would fall. Had the policy been introduced earlier, the outcome might have been different.

3. Participle clauses. The most reliable band-7 signal, because few candidates at band 6 use them.

Faced with rising costs, many families postpone university. Having completed their degrees, graduates often emigrate.

4. Cleft sentences for emphasis.

What matters most is not the funding but its distribution. It is the lack of enforcement, rather than the law itself, that causes this.

5. Concessive subordination.

While technology has improved access, it has not improved outcomes. Although the evidence is mixed, the trend is clear.

6. Nominalisation — turning verbs into nouns, the hallmark of academic register.

Instead of: *The government decided to reduce spending, and this affected hospitals.* Write: *The government's decision to reduce spending affected hospitals.*

The French and Arabic interference checklist

These are the errors that will hold your Grammatical Range & Accuracy at 6. Check for them explicitly before submitting anything.

Articles with abstract nouns. French keeps the definite article where English drops it.

the society → *society* · the nature → *nature* · the technology → *technology* · the life → *life* · the history → *history*

Uncountable nouns pluralised. French pluralises these freely; English cannot.

informations → *information* · researches → *research* · advices → *advice* · knowledges → *knowledge* · equipments → *equipment* · furnitures → *furniture* · softwares → *software* · evidences → *evidence*

Use *a piece of research, some advice, a great deal of information.*

Prepositions.

depend on (not of, from *dépendre de*) · *discuss* Ø *something* (not *discuss about*) · *arrive in* a country, *at* a building · *participate in* · *consist of* · *married to* · *interested in* · *suffer from* · *responsible for* · *on the other hand* (not in the other hand)

False friends. The dangerous ones, because they produce a real English word in the wrong place, so nothing looks misspelled:

actually = *at present* ≠ *actuellement* (*currently*) · eventually = *in the end* ≠ *éventuellement* (*possibly*) · assist = *to help* ≠ *assister à* (*to attend*) · formation ≠ *training or education* · sensible = *having good judgement* ≠ *sensitive* · library ≠ *librairie* (*bookshop*) · deception = *trickery* ≠ *déception* (*disappointment*) · support = *to bear or back* ≠ *supporter* (*to tolerate*) · achieve ≠ *achever* (*to finish*) · *significative* is not an English word → **significant**

Verb agreement and stacked verbs.

peoples are depend → *people depend* · he do not → *he does not* · the government are decide → *the government has decided*

People is already plural. Never place a bare auxiliary against a bare verb.

Run-on sentences. French and Arabic rhetorical structure both tolerate long chains joined by commas and *and*, where English wants a full stop or a subordinator. This single habit can hold Coherence & Cohesion at 6 by itself. When a sentence passes about 25 words, look for the place it should have ended.

Also watch: *since* versus *for* · *in my opinion I think* (pick one) · missing third-person -s · comma splices · overformal register borrowed from French academic writing.

Chapter 8 — Vocabulary: collocation over rarity

The principle

Lexical Resource does not measure how rare your words are. It measures **precision, flexibility and collocation**. Band 7 is the *right* word; band 9 is the right word used with full naturalness. A rare word in the wrong collocation scores **below** a common word in the right one.

| ameliorate the pecuniary situation — *lower than* — improve finances

Learn collocations, not words

Research is useless on its own. What you need is:

| **conduct** research · **carry out** research · research **into** something · **groundbreaking** research

Make research is the error that reveals a band-6 candidate.

Every entry in your vocabulary bank carries two or three real collocations. That column is the point of the file.

Two anti-rules

No forced idioms in Writing. Idiomatic language belongs in Speaking, where it raises Lexical Resource. In Task 2 it reads as informal and can lower it. *Every cloud has a silver lining* in an academic essay is a register error.

No thesaurus substitution. Replacing every common word with a synonym produces unnatural collocations and *lowers* your band. Vary vocabulary where you genuinely know the alternative works — otherwise repeat the correct word. Repeat is not a crime; wrong is.

Build by topic

IELTS recycles a predictable set: education · technology · environment · health · work and careers · urbanisation · crime and justice · media and advertising · travel and tourism · culture and tradition · family and society · government and public spending · science and research · globalisation · art and creativity.

Ten well-chosen items per topic, with collocations, beats a thousand isolated words. Aim for precise mid-frequency academic vocabulary, not showpieces.

Paraphrase is a testable skill

Both Reading and Speaking reward it directly, and Writing requires it in every introduction. Practise actively: take a sentence and rewrite it three ways without changing the meaning. In Speaking, not knowing a word costs nothing — what you do next decides the band. *I can't remember the exact term, but it's the process where...* is a band-7 move, not a failure.

Chapter 9 — The 30-day plan

Built around the commands in this repository, at **90 minutes a day**.

Adjust this to your real test date. Once the date is set in `CLAUDE.md`, `/review` rebuilds the schedule around the actual days remaining. If you have more than 30 days, repeat weeks 2 and 3 — they carry the highest-value work. If you have fewer, keep the mocks and the error review and cut the theory.

The ratio

70% practice with feedback · 20% error review · 10% theory.

Reading about IELTS does not raise your band. Being corrected does, and rereading your own corrections does. If you are spending more than about ten minutes a day reading strategy, you have the ratio wrong.

Week 1 — Baseline and diagnosis

Establish where you actually are. Do not skip this; targeting without a baseline wastes the other three weeks.

Day	Session
1	<code>/writing2</code> — full drill. This is your baseline.
2	<code>/reading</code> + one official free Reading passage, timed
3	<code>/writing1</code> + <code>/vocab</code> ADD (environment)
4	<code>/listening</code> + one official free Listening test under real conditions
5	<code>/speaking</code> — record yourself
6	Official practice test section + <code>/official</code> debrief
7	<code>/review</code> — first real weak-area diagnosis + rest

Week 2 — Attack the weakest criterion

By now `/review` has named your limiting criterion. Everything this week targets it.

Day	Session
8	<code>/writing2</code> — the family you scored lowest on
9	<code>/reading</code> — your weakest question type + timed passage
10	<code>/writing1</code> + <code>/vocab</code> QUIZ
11	<code>/listening</code> — prediction and trap drills + official test
12	<code>/speaking</code> — focus on Part 3, where band 7 is decided
13	<code>/mock</code> — full 60-minute Writing test
14	<code>/review</code> + <code>/handbook</code> — generate your personal book

Week 3 — Consolidate and raise the ceiling

Day	Session
15	/writing2 — a different family
16	/reading — full 3-passage official test, strictly timed
17	/writing1 — a visual type you have not done
18	/listening + spelling dictation drill
19	/speaking — full simulation, recorded
20	/writing2 + /vocab QUIZ
21	/review + reread your top 3 error patterns

Week 4 — Test conditions and taper

Day	Session
22	/mock
23	Full official Listening + Reading, back to back, timed
24	/writing2 — your weakest family, one more time
25	/speaking — full simulation
26	/official debrief of everything from days 22–23
27	/handbook — regenerate; this is your revision book
28	Light: reread handbook.md , /vocab QUIZ
29	Light: one Task 2 under time, no grading. Confirm logistics.
30	Rest. Reread handbook.md once. Sleep.

Do not cram on day 29 or 30. Fatigue costs more marks than a missed drill gains, and Writing accuracy is the first thing tiredness destroys.

Chapter 10 — Exam-day protocol

Before

Confirm the delivery mode. Assume computer-delivered — paper is being retired from mid-2026 — unless your booking says otherwise. If your centre offers "Writing on Paper", decide in advance which you want and practise that way.

Bring the ID you booked with. Arrive early. Sleep matters more than one last revision session.

Listening (~30 min)

Read the questions during every pause. Predict the answer type for every gap. Type as you listen.

No transfer time on computer — you get **2 minutes** at the end. Use it for spelling and plurals only, never for reconsidering answers, which usually makes them worse.

If you lose your place, jump forward. Answers come in order; chasing costs more than it recovers. Never leave a blank.

Reading (60 min)

Set hard stops — about 20 minutes per passage, or the front-loaded 16/19/21 split if you have practised it. Obey them even when a question is nearly solved.

Do Matching Headings early, Matching Information last. No transfer time — write answers in their final form as you go. Never leave a blank, but do not reflex-guess Not Given: decide from what you actually read.

Writing (60 min)

If you are prone to running out of time, **do Task 2 first** — it is worth double. Otherwise 20 minutes and 40 minutes.

Spend five minutes planning Task 2. Underline every part of the question. Check the on-screen word count; do not estimate it. Leave three minutes to proofread for your own known errors — articles with abstract nouns, uncountables, third-person -s, run-ons.

Task 1 without an overview cannot reach band 7. Write the overview first if you must.

Speaking (11–14 min)

Arrive with your voice warmed up — speak English aloud for ten minutes beforehand.

Extend every Part 1 answer to two or three sentences. Use the full preparation minute in Part 2 for keywords, not sentences, and speak for the full two minutes. In Part 3, expect pushback and treat it as an invitation to defend your view, not an attack.

Do not perform. Do not deploy memorised chunks. If you do not know a word, paraphrase — that is a band-7 move.

If you panic

Note the paper, breathe, and use the rule for that paper: *guess and move on* in Listening; *hard stop and move to the next passage* in Reading; *write the overview, then the bodies* in Task 1; *answer the question that was asked* in Task 2; *answer, reason, example* in Speaking.

One bad section does not decide your overall band. The average of four does, and a 5.5 in one paper is survivable if the other three hold.

Afterwards

Results are available in a few days for computer-delivered tests. If one skill falls short, check whether **One Skill Retake** is available at your centre — it is offered in over 110 countries but availability in Tunisia could not be confirmed from official sources, so ask when you book rather than assuming.

Scores are valid for two years.